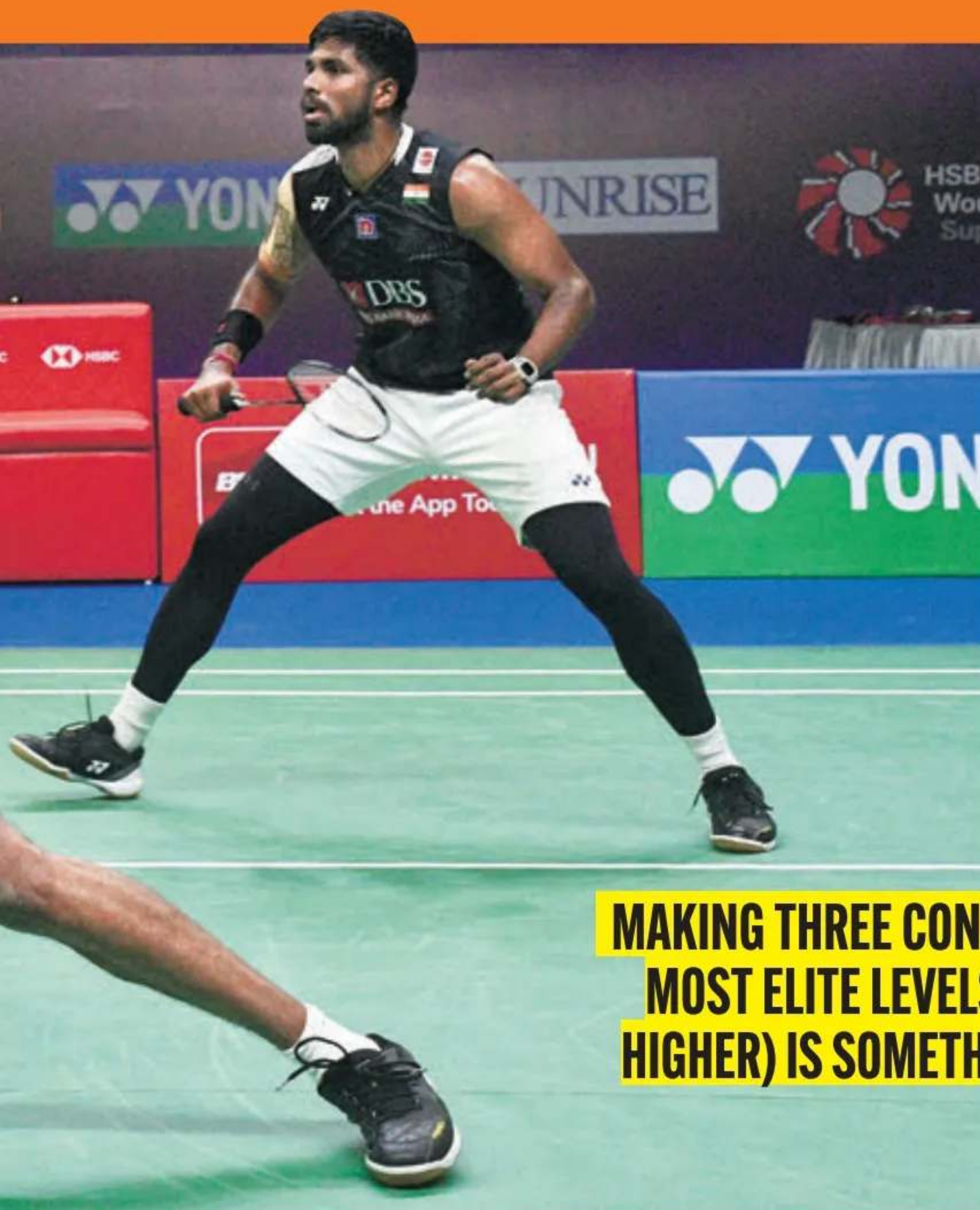




MAKING THREE CONSECUTIVE FINALS AT THE MOST ELITE LEVELS (WORLD TOUR 750 AND HIGHER) IS SOMETHING UNPRECEDENTED IN INDIAN BADMINTON



Strong show: For over five tournaments in nearly two years, Satwik-Chirag had not lost a final. Their recent defeats have put a major dent to their reputation as finals specialists, even though they have come against the very best — World champions Kang and Seo (below) and former World No. 1, Liang Weikeng and Wang Chang from China.

Pics: SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

decider and egged them on during each point as they inched closer to the Koreans.

Although the Indians had their chances in the final game — they had closed the gap to just one point at 15-16 and 18-19 — the Koreans held their nerve. At the end of the final point, there was a pall of disappointment across the stadium.

The Korean pair — who are the reigning world champions — had snapped a three-match losing streak against the Indians, including one in the Malaysia Open semifinals a week before this match.

For over five tournaments in nearly two years, Satwik-Chirag had not lost a final. But the India Open defeat is now their third consecutive loss in finals — the previous two being the China Masters last November and the Malaysia Open. It's a major dent to their reputation as finals specialists.

Although they would have been hurting after the loss, Chirag and Satwik would acknowledge that their disappointment was naturally relative. Making three consecutive finals at the most elite levels (World Tour 750 and higher) is something